of the churches and the liturgy much simpler than they are in Central Europe where the appeal of the baroque is still strong.[16] Similar trends can be seen in Germany and the Netherlands.

But as a result of this ‘depletion’, some in the Catholic Church have begun to show greater interest in Orthodox Christianity and its spirituality, rich in ritual, lengthy ceremonies, incomprehensible ancient texts and holy pictures.

Others – out of similar motives – have opted for a revived interest in the Latin mass.[17] And not only that: across Europe and the US, some Catholics, clergy and laity alike, are turning away from what they see as a liberal relativism seeping into the Church. In their eyes, the conclusion of the Second Vatican Council provided a Catholic equivalent for such doctrinal backsliding. Thus conservatism is on the rise in many quarters within the Catholic Church all over the world, though in many places facing opposition by moderate and liberal Catholics. In Poland, a conservative position, fuelled by strong Catholic tradition, an urban-rural divide and conspiracy theories helped replace the political liberal elite and sustains on the surface the Law and Justice Party of Mr Kaczyński. This put Poland on a path that within a decade led to a collision with the European liberal mainstream. I shall elaborate this in more detail in the final chapter, but at this stage it is important to understand the religious factors behind these political developments.

What later become the Orthodox Church approached the Slavs with a tailor-made scripture based on the Greek alphabet – Glagolitic, and then with the Cyrillic script, which both have special characters for some of the sounds found in the early Slavic languages. These scripts seemed better suited for writing down the Slavic languages. Indeed, in some ways, it could be said that Orthodox Christianity in general seems ‘more Slavic’, as it holds memories of the primordial unity of Slavs in the times of Constantine and Methodius. By the same token, the Slavs of Central Europe (Slovenians, Croats, Slovaks, Czechs, Poles) are somehow ‘less Slav’ than those further east, as their identity has also a strong imprint of the Germanic (and Latin) world – a subject I will deal with in the following chapter.

As we can see, Eastern Europe too is religiously and culturally divided between its own East and West, though there are still visible traces of the bond that once linked the two in a single Slavic entity. While the majority